

India Itinerary

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Kolkata in a Day: Rosogolla, College Street & the Mess of Buses

This wasn't a planned trip. I was in Kolkata on 22nd January 2026 for my **US visa biometric appointment** — fly in, get fingerprinted, fly out. But the biometric was done by 9:45am, my flight was at night, and Aayushi had already messaged me a list of places and sweets I had to hit. So between two airport runs I had myself a small, accidental day in Kolkata.

Solo trip. One backpack. One city to figure out before sundown. Here's how it went.

The 10-Minute Biometric & the Real Day Beginning

I'd landed the previous night at 11pm and the hotel surprised me with a free room upgrade — a small kindness after a long day. McDonald's delivery, dinner in bed, lights out.

Up at 7am. Ready by 8:15. The appointment office was a ten-minute drive away. They let me in at 9:15am for a 9:30 slot, and it was over almost before it began: passport check, photograph, fingerprints, done. Back at the hotel by 9:45am with the whole day in front of me. I checked out, dropped my bag at the concierge, opened Aayushi's list, and started walking.

KC Das: The Original Rosogolla

I was staying in the **Park Street** area, so **KC Das** was a walk away. The shop is a Kolkata landmark — the family credited (depending on who you ask) with inventing the modern spongy **rosogolla**. You can read the legend on the wall, but the real test is in the bite.

I started with one rosogolla standing right there at the counter. Warm syrup, cool centre, that clean cardamom-water finish you don't get anywhere else. Then I bought a **canned pack for Golu** back home — they vacuum-seal them so they survive a flight, which became important later.

College Street: A Book Market Bigger Than Delhi's

I tried being clever and catching a bus to Indian Coffee House. After ten minutes of standing at the wrong stop watching the wrong numbers go by, I gave up and walked to **Esplanade** for the metro. Got down at **Mahatma Gandhi Road** and stepped straight into **College Street**.

I've been to Daryaganj's Sunday book bazaar in Delhi. College Street is bigger. Stall after stall, deep into the lanes, textbooks stacked taller than the men selling them, second-hand novels in fading covers, Bengali periodicals tied in twine. You can spend a full day just here if you're the kind of person who buys books faster than you can read them. I was on a clock, so I let myself wander one row, photographed it, and kept walking.

Indian Coffee House: Butter Toast & Special Cold Coffee

The **Indian Coffee House** on College Street is the big sister of the one in Delhi — bigger hall, taller ceilings, more turbaned waiters gliding between marble-topped tables. It feels like a place where students have been arguing about politics and poetry for seventy years, because they have.

I ordered **butter toast** and a **special cold coffee**. Both are old-school perfect — the toast crisped on a flat tava with a slick of yellow butter, the coffee thick and sweet, served in a tall stainless tumbler. For me, an outsider, it was pure nostalgia for a thing I'd never actually lived. That's the trick of these places.

"Taking metro around the world is very easy. Taking a bus around India is very tough."

Girish Chandra Dey: A Sweet Shop Where You Need a Translator

Girish Chandra Dey & Nakur Chandra Nandy was a short walk from the coffee house. The display case is overwhelming — twenty kinds of **sandesh**, kheer kadam, nolen gur specials in winter, a dozen things I had no name for. I ate too many standing right there at the counter, then completely lost the plot trying to decide what to pack for Golu and the office.

The shopkeeper saw me staring helplessly and just took over — picked two assortments, packed them in those classic Bengali sweet boxes with the twine, told me what would survive a flight and what wouldn't. I paid, nodded, and walked out with arms full of cardboard. Best thing that happened to me all day.

Howrah Bridge & Two Jetty Rides on the Hooghly

I decided to be brave about buses again and somehow managed to catch one to **Howrah**. Mistake noted: the bus does eventually take you there, but Howrah on a weekday is its own kind of mayhem.

Kolkata, to me, is a mix of Delhi and Mumbai — Delhi's old-city texture, Mumbai's coastal-port energy. And **Howrah is the city's Chandni Chowk**. Wall-to-wall people, every inch of pavement claimed by a hawker, the bridge hanging above it all like a steel cathedral.

I took **two jetty rides** across the Hooghly, mostly for the breeze and the view of the bridge from the water. Worth every rupee. Try catching a bus *back* from Howrah though and you'll understand why I gave up and walked half a kilometre to a metro station instead.

Belgachia & the Wrong Jain Temple

Metro to **Belgachia**. E-rickshaw to what I'd convinced myself was the **Sheeshe Wala Mandir** (the famous mirror-and-glass Jain temple). It wasn't. It was a perfectly nice Jain temple — quiet, well-kept, the kind of place worth a fifteen-minute pause — but it was not the one on the postcards.

The priest there pointed me onward. **Bus to Maniktala**, get down one stop early — I'd been tracing the route on Google Maps and realised the earlier stop dropped me closer to the temple gate.

The Glass Temple at Maniktala (Built 1867)

This was the one. The **Shantinath Jain Temple at Maniktala**, built in 1867, every inch of its interior inlaid with mirror, coloured glass, and Belgian chandeliers that catch the late-afternoon light and throw it back at you in fragments. It is genuinely beautiful, and it is genuinely worth the wrong-temple detour and the bus-stop confusion to get there.

I took my pictures, sat for a few minutes in the quiet, and then realised I was running out of day.

Arsanal Veg Roll & the Cab to the Airport

I'd seen **Arsanal** on Google with 41,000 ratings — that kind of number in Kolkata is a signal, not a fluke. One more bus ride to get there, which turned into a small soap opera: solid traffic, then a full-volume argument between two women in the middle of the aisle that the conductor refused to referee. We all just sat with it until I finally got off.

Packed one **veg roll** at Arsanal — the Kolkata kathi roll, paratha around a hot vegetable filling with onion and lime — gave up on bus karma, and called a cab. Even the cab took its time in the traffic, but

I made it to the airport by 8pm. I checked the bag in (the rosogolla can was the actual VIP of this trip and I wasn't letting it travel as cabin) and went looking for the lounge.

A Note on Travelling Alone

"The only demerit of travelling alone is the eating part. You don't feel like going to a restaurant alone — or maybe that's just me."

By the time I was in the lounge, I was bone-tired and not even hungry. That's the honest thing about solo travel for me — the seeing and the walking and the metro and the bus chaos, all of that was great. The eating is the part where being alone shows up. A TV or a laptop in front of me might have helped. Sitting with just a plate and your own thoughts after twelve hours of decisions is harder than it sounds.

Still — Kolkata in a day, between two flights, was a good day. The city does not need a week to make a case for itself. One walk through College Street and one ride across the Hooghly and you already know you'll be back.

Day-Trip Cheat Sheet: Kolkata Between Flights

- **KC Das (Esplanade):** The original spongy rosogolla. Buy a canned pack — it survives a flight.
- **College Street + Indian Coffee House:** Walk the book market, then go up for butter toast and cold coffee.
- **Girish Chandra Dey & Nakur Chandra Nandy:** Sandesh heaven. Let the shopkeeper pick for you.
- **Howrah Bridge + Hooghly jetty:** Cross the river by ferry for the best bridge view. Avoid the buses back.
- **Shantinath Jain Temple, Maniktala (Sheeshe Wala Mandir):** 1867 glass-inlay temple. Worth the detour.
- **Arsanal kathi roll:** Pack a veg roll for the airport. Don't underestimate Kolkata traffic — cab earlier than you think.
- **Transport tip:** Metro is your friend. Buses are unreliable for outsiders. Don't be a hero.

Maharashtra: Mumbai, Pune & the Western Ghats

This page is a work in progress. We've called Maharashtra home for years — Mumbai's coastline, monsoon weekends in Lonavala and Mahabaleshwar, road trips to Ajanta-Ellora, and the Konkan coast running south to Goa. The full guide is being written.

What's coming

- Mumbai — South Bombay walks, Marine Drive, Bandra cafes
- Pune weekend itineraries
- Lonavala & Mahabaleshwar monsoon hits
- Ajanta & Ellora caves from Aurangabad
- Konkan coast drive

In the meantime, browse our other destinations or read the Kolkata day-trip diary.

Karnataka: Bangalore, Coorg, Hampi & the Coast

This page is a work in progress. Karnataka has been one of our most-returned-to states — Bangalore as a launchpad, Coorg coffee weekends, Mysore palaces, the surreal boulder fields of Hampi, and the slow coastal stretch from Mangalore to Gokarna. The full guide is being written.

What's coming

- Bangalore — neighbourhoods, cafes, weekend escapes
- Mysore Palace & Chamundi Hills
- Coorg — Madikeri, plantations, Abbey Falls
- Chikmagalur coffee trails
- Hampi — the boulder kingdom
- Udupi, Mangalore & Gokarna coast

Meanwhile, browse our other destinations or read the Kolkata day-trip diary.

Hyderabad: Charminar, Biryani & the Tech City

This page is a work in progress. Hyderabad is the city that hands you Nizami history in the morning, glass-tower tech parks in the afternoon, and the country's most argued-about biryani at dinner. The full guide is being written.

What's coming

- Charminar & Laad Bazaar bangles
- Golconda Fort sound & light show
- Qutb Shahi tombs
- Hussain Sagar & the Buddha statue
- Ramoji Film City day trip
- Irani chai & biryani — where we actually go

Meanwhile, browse our other destinations or read the Kolkata day-trip diary.

Andaman Islands: Port Blair, Havelock & Neil

This page is a work in progress. The Andamans are India's quiet superpower — turquoise water, surprisingly empty beaches, the heavy history of Cellular Jail, and ferries that you have to plan around. The full guide is being written.

What's coming

- Port Blair — Cellular Jail, Ross Island, the light-and-sound show
- Havelock (Swaraj Dweep) — Radhanagar Beach, scuba operators we trusted
- Neil Island (Shaheed Dweep) — Natural Bridge, Bharatpur Beach
- Ferry logistics — Makruzz vs Green Ocean, when to book
- Vegetarian food honesty in island kitchens

Meanwhile, browse our other destinations or read the Kolkata day-trip diary.

South India Road Trip 2025: Malvan to Pune in a Polo, with Parents

This was the trip we had been postponing for years. A proper **family road trip** — me, Harshit, and both sets of parents — in a single **Volkswagen Polo**, with Harshit doing every kilometre of the driving. Thirteen days, eleven stops, one coastline, two Karnataka hill towns, the giant Bahubali at Shravanabelagola, the ruins at Hampi, and a final crawl back up to Pune.

The brief from the parents was simple: *jain temples first, everything else around them*. So most nights we slept in **Jain dharamshalas** — clean, simple, vegetarian, almost always cheaper than a hotel and a hundred times warmer. Touristy stops fit in between. We started on **20th December 2025** in Malvan and finished on **1st January 2026** in Pune with a deliberate “do nothing” day.

“Harshit drove the entire route. Parents in the back, Google Maps in the front, and a thermos of chai that refused to run out.”

Day 1: 20th December Driving Down to Malvan

We pulled out early and pointed the Polo south down the Konkan. The first leg is the longest stretch of road on the whole trip and there is no clever way around it — you just put the music on, rotate snacks, and let the coast slowly arrive. By the time we reached **Malvan** it was already evening and the air had that salt-and-fried-fish smell that tells you you’ve definitely left the city behind.

Dinner was simple and we crashed early. The parents were the real heroes — ten hours in a Polo and they still asked if there was a temple to visit before bed.

Day 2: 21st December Malvan — Tarkarli, Sindhudurg & the Beach Day

This was the proper Malvan day. **Tarkarli beach** in the morning — long, clean, and surprisingly empty for a Sunday. We watched the boats go out, walked the sand for a while, and resisted (politely) the scuba operators trying to push us into the water. With parents along, the calculus on water sports changes.

Later we did the boat across to **Sindhudurg Fort** — Shivaji’s sea fort sitting on its own little rock island. The boatman doubled as a guide and the ramparts were the kind of place where you put your phone away for ten minutes just to look. Veg thali for lunch, ice cream the parents pretended not to want, and back to the room by sunset.

Day 3: 22nd December Malvan → Gokarna

Down the coast into Karnataka. The drive to **Gokarna** is one of those routes where the road keeps flirting with the sea — you turn a corner and the Arabian Sea is back, you turn another and it’s palms again. We reached by afternoon and went straight to the **Mahabaleshwar Temple** for darshan. Gokarna is a pilgrim town that has, somewhere along the way, also become a backpacker town, and the two crowds pass each other on the same lane without quite acknowledging each other.

We did not do the famous beach trek — Om, Half-Moon, Paradise — because parents and steep cliff paths is not a combination I was going to suggest. **Kudle Beach** at sunset was enough. Hot bhajiyas,

cutting chai, the sky doing its show for free.

Day 4: 23rd December

Karkala & Varanga — The Jain Day

This was the day the trip's real spine showed itself. We drove inland to **Karkala** for the **Gomateshwara monolith** — a 42-foot statue of Bahubali standing on a hill since 1432, smaller cousin to the more famous one at Shravanabelagola but no less striking when you climb up and find yourself standing at his feet. Quiet, wind-blown, very few other visitors. The parents lit incense; I took pictures I knew I'd come back to.

From Karkala we drove to **Varanga** for the **Kere Basadi** — the lake temple. The Basadi sits in the middle of a small lake and you reach it on a flat little boat punted across by a temple-hand. The whole experience is about five minutes long and you remember it for years. Built around the 12th century, dedicated to Neminatha, and one of the quietest temples I've been inside in India.

Night was in a **Jain dharamshala** — spotless, fan working, hot water at 6am, total bill less than dinner-for-two in Mumbai.

"Kere Basadi on its little lake is the kind of temple that doesn't need a queue or a sign or a story. You just sit on the boat and arrive."

Day 5: 24th December

Drive into Coorg

Up early and into the Western Ghats. The road climbs out of the coastal plain and the temperature drops about a degree every twenty minutes — by the time we hit **Madikeri** the sweaters were out and the windows were down for entirely different reasons. **Coorg** smells of coffee even before you see a plantation, which is, I think, the whole point.

Quiet evening at the homestay. Hot soup, a fireplace that genuinely worked, parents enjoying themselves visibly.

Day 6: 25th December

Coorg Full Day — Plantation, Falls, Temple

Christmas morning in a coffee plantation is a slightly absurd, very pleasant thing. We did a plantation walk in the morning — the host explained Arabica vs Robusta, picked a few beans for us to smell, showed us the pepper vines climbing up the same trees. Then **Abbey Falls** (touristy but worth the twenty minutes), and on the way back the **Omkareshwara Temple** in Madikeri — the one with the unusual Indo-Islamic dome that always confuses first-time visitors.

Lunch was the local **akki roti and pandi curry** — pork for those who eat it; the parents stuck to veg and were perfectly happy with the bamboo shoot curry and the akki roti, which is rice flour flatbread cooked on a hot tava and improves with ghee.

Day 7: 26th December

Coorg → Mysuru

Down out of the hills and into **Mysuru**. There is exactly one thing you have to do on your first day in Mysuru and that is the **Mysuru Palace** — the Indo-Saracenic one, the official residence of the Wadiyars, the one that gets lit up with 97,000 bulbs on Sundays. We were not there on a Sunday so

we got the daytime version, which is plenty — the durbar hall, the painted ceilings, the stained glass, the marble floor your bare feet remember for the next two hours.

Evening walk on **Devaraja Market** for the flowers, fruits, and sandalwood soap that everyone buys and nobody regrets. Dinner: thali, again, and nobody complained.

Day 8: 27th December

Shravanabelagola — The Giant Bahubali

This was the temple day everyone had been building up to. **Shravanabelagola** — the 57-foot monolithic statue of **Bahubali (Gomateshwara)** carved out of a single granite outcrop in 981 CE, sitting on top of **Vindhyagiri Hill**. To reach him you climb **614 steps** barefoot up the bare rock. We did it in the early morning when the granite is still cool enough to walk on. The parents took it slow; we all made it.

Standing at his feet at the top, with the plains stretching out in every direction, is one of those moments that does not need to be explained to anyone who has done it. The statue itself is over a thousand years old, calm in a way modern things are not, and the silence on the hill at 8am is almost embarrassing.

Back down, a long lunch at the **Jain bhojanalaya** at the base, and then on the road again.

Day 9: 28th December

Drive to Hampi

The drive from Shravanabelagola to **Hampi** is long and the landscape changes character about three times along the way — cultivated plains, then dry scrub, then the boulder country that tells you you're close. We checked in late afternoon on the Hampi Bazaar side, walked down to the **Virupaksha Temple** for the evening aarti, and called it a day.

Day 10: 29th December

Hampi Full Day — Vijayanagara Ruins

You cannot do Hampi justice in a day. We tried anyway. Hired an auto-driver-cum-guide for the morning circuit — **Virupaksha** in detail, the **Vittala Temple** with its stone chariot and the musical pillars, the **King's Balance**, **Hemakuta Hill**, and the **Queen's Bath**. Afternoon for the Royal Enclosure side — **Lotus Mahal**, **Elephant Stables**, **Mahanavami Dibba**.

Hampi is an empire that ended in 1565 and is still telling its story. The scale of it — 26 square kilometres of ruins, give or take — only really lands when you stand on a hill and look at boulder fields with temple towers poking out of them. Sunset from **Hemakuta Hill** is the photograph everyone takes and it is, embarrassingly, exactly as good as the photographs suggest.

"Hampi makes you think about how the world ends — not with a bang, but with stones, slowly, in a beautiful place."

Day 11: 30th December

Hampi → Kolhapur

Long driving day. We made it up to **Kolhapur** by evening for darshan at the **Mahalakshmi (Ambabai) Temple** — one of the **Shakti Peethas** and the spiritual centre of the city. The temple has the kind of energy that does not need to be marketed; the queue moves, the chants carry, the bell sounds louder

than you expect.

Dinner was the obvious one — Kolhapur is famous for its **misal** and a sweet shop in every lane. Parents asked for less spice. The cook smiled politely and ignored the request. It was still excellent.

Day 12: 31st December

Kolhapur → Pune

Shorter drive, easier day. We reached **Pune** by afternoon. New Year's Eve in Pune with parents was deliberately low-key — a quiet dinner, a walk on **FC Road**, and back to the room before midnight got noisy. The Polo got a wash. Harshit, who had driven every kilometre of the last twelve days, finally let his shoulders down.

Day 13: 1st January

The Chill Day

We had built this day in on purpose. No driving. No temple. No fort. Late breakfast, longer lunch, a Pune cafe in the afternoon, and an early dinner. The parents called relatives and reported, slightly exaggerated, on every place we had seen. Harshit slept. I went through the photos.

If you take one thing from this diary, let it be this: **build a chill day into the end of any road trip**. The trip is not finished on the last drive; it is finished on the day after, when you sit still and let it settle.

Practical Notes from the Polo

- **Car:** Volkswagen Polo, five adults, manageable but tight. Soft bags over suitcases.
- **Driver:** Harshit drove the whole route. We rotated only the navigation, not the wheel.
- **Stay:** Jain dharamshalas wherever available — Karkala, Varanga, Shravanabelagola, Kolhapur. Clean, vegetarian, very affordable. Book ahead by phone; most do not show on the booking sites.
- **Food:** Pure veg the whole trip. Easy on this route — every dharamshala bhojanalaya serves an unlimited thali for very little money.
- **Roads:** Konkan coast to Karnataka is good but slow. Karkala to Coorg climbs a lot. Hampi roads are fine. Kolhapur to Pune is highway.
- **Pace:** 13 days felt right. Don't try to do this in 10.

Road-Trip Cheat Sheet: Malvan to Pune (Dec 2025)

- **Malvan:** Tarkarli beach, Sindhudurg Fort by boat. Two nights is right.
- **Gokarna:** Mahabaleshwar Temple + Kudle Beach at sunset. Skip the beach trek if travelling with parents.
- **Karkala & Varanga:** Gomateshwara monolith at Karkala; Kere Basadi lake temple at Varanga. Both quiet, both special.
- **Coorg:** Plantation walk, Abbey Falls, Omkareshwara Temple, akki roti and bamboo shoot curry.
- **Mysuru:** Palace by day; Devaraja Market in the evening.
- **Shravanabelagola:** 614 barefoot steps to a 57-foot Bahubali. Go before 9am.

- **Hampi:** Hire a guide-auto. Virupaksha & Vittala in the morning, Royal Enclosure in the afternoon, Hemakuta at sunset.
- **Kolhapur:** Mahalakshmi Temple darshan + Kolhapuri misal.
- **Pune:** One slow day to land.
- **Build a chill day** at the end. Non-negotiable.

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